

UNDERSTORY

Decision Register v6 - Story, Mechanics, Monetization, IP, and Mockup Gates

Purpose

This PDF lists the decisions still needed for the story to work, the mechanics to work, and the product to make money without alienating players. It is deliberately practical: what must be locked, why it matters, and when it blocks production.

Current spine

Understory is an iOS-first tapper-builder set in AD 9026 on a high mountain above the Veil. The player descends through a found Bore, excavates upward through ancient human history, restores Old Lungs and Breathlines, clears the Veil, and carves downward outside the mountain into newly visible land.

Top decisions to lock next

Decision	Current lean	Why it matters	Lock timing
Final title and subtitle	Understory as working title	Affects store pitch, brand memory, and whether HEM appears publicly.	Before public tests
HEM relationship	Standalone Understory with HEM donor DNA	Prevents old scattered-world promises from confusing this product.	Before marketing copy
Current date	AD 9026	Gives enough future distance for myth and recovery while keeping humanity relatable.	Locked unless marketing issue
Ancient human start	c. 8000 BC, adjustable to 10,000-6000 BC	Defines the underground as ancient-first without fake-Egypt baggage.	Before age art pass
Before-Us date	c. 5,000,000 BC or soft deep-time range	Adds deep mystery but must not break human-origin plausibility.	Long game
The Veil composition	Cloud, haze, toxic weather, machine residue, myth	Explains why people did not descend outside the mountain.	Phase 0 visual
Long Cooling + Drawdown Works	Both, with Drawdown as local machine accelerant	Makes recovery feel plausible and gives land unlock a machine body.	Phase 1
Ancient tech tone	Ritual infrastructure, not clean sci-fi	Lets "magic" be advanced tech without breaking tone.	Phase 1 art
Far Peak reveal	After first Veil clearing	Creates hope and scale without overloading onboarding.	Phase 1/2
Last Ghost Map	Late authorship turn	The player stops restoring and starts becoming an ancestor.	Long game

Story decisions

Decision	Current lean	Why it matters	Lock timing
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Narrative lock order

- First truth: we need the mountain to live.
- Second truth: the mountain remembers people.
- Third truth: the mountain remembers us.
- Fourth truth: we were not the first us.
- Final truth: inherited history ends, and the player builds the next layer.

Mechanics decisions

Decision	Current lean	Why it matters	Lock timing
First 10-minute script	Summit -> Bore -> seam -> haul -> refine -> build	This is the breath test for the whole product.	Now
World map format	Mountain landmarks plus Core Sample index	Avoids spatial confusion from outside-down / inside-up geometry.	Phase 0
Spiral scale	Stub small first, expand later	Prevents geometry from becoming production drag.	Phase 0
Tapper timer ladder	2m, 15m, 1h, 4h, 8h, 8-12h cap	Defines return rhythm and notification cadence.	Economy prototype
Daily block target	60-120 early placed block equivalents	Makes scarcity meaningful without freezing the builder.	Economy prototype
Free drafting constraints	Unlimited-ish early, summarized by want-list	Keeps dry sessions playable.	Phase 0
Trace seam accessibility	Visual/audio fallback plus haptics where available	Touch feel is the premium signature.	Phase 0
Support and collapse	Bury, never destroy	Failure must not feel like monetized punishment.	Phase 1
Water	Authored hard stop first, no full sim	Second hazard can explode scope if simulated too early.	Phase 1
Light	Expressive first, systemic later only if needed	Keeps darkness cozy-strange, not hostile survival.	Phase 0/1
Crew morale	Fiction-first, possible rate modifier later	Avoids full sim before notes and rituals prove warmth.	Phase 1

Math decisions and assumptions

Area	Working assumption	Why
Session range	30 seconds to 20+ minutes	Covers claim-checks and iPad building without changing product identity.
Early daily output	60-120 placed block equivalents	Enough for a room or visible progress, not enough for instant castles.
First authored haul	12-24 commit-ready blocks	Lets the player build in minute one without killing scarcity.
First draft size	40-60 blocks	Creates a visible want-list and reason to return.
Offline cap	8-12 productive hours	Protects return rhythm while Lapse Ceremony handles long absences.
Subscription revenue	\$6.99 gross gives about \$4.89 first-year net before tax	At this price, about 2,045 subscribers are needed for \$10k net/month from subs alone.
MAU need	About 41k-68k MAU at 5%-3% sub conversion	Shows why direct purchases, seasons, and retention matter.

Important note

The timer and block numbers are not final balancing. They are a scaffold to test whether scarcity creates desire without creating dead sessions. Free drafting is the safety valve.

Business and monetization decisions

Decision	Current lean	Why it matters	Lock timing
Primary model	Subscription with ongoing chapter/content value	Supports live authored ages without selling rare materials.	Pre-soft-launch
Monthly price	\$5.99-\$7.99 hypothesis	Revenue target depends heavily on sub conversion and trust.	Price test
Annual price	\$39.99-\$59.99 hypothesis	Improves retention and cash flow if updates are credible.	Price test
Named crew	Direct purchase, no randomization	Adds revenue and emotional fiction without gacha.	After crew warmth proof
Seasonal expeditions	Paid chapters or subscriber-included content	Best long-term revenue if content cadence is real.	Phase 2
Refine skips	Optional, refine-only, never dig/land/rare	Potential revenue but trust risk.	Explicit go/no-go
Rewarded ads	Opt-in only, removed by sub	Supports free users without forced ad poison.	Soft launch
IP/license	Original IP first; public-domain-inspired events later	Licenses can distort the product before retention is proven.	After retention proof

Anti-alienation covenant

- No coins or abstract premium currency.
- No loot boxes, gacha, or randomized paid rewards.
- No purchasable rare materials or land.
- No purchase prompt at hard stops, collapse, flood, scarcity, rare finds, or story gates.
- Paid offers appear only in calm places: Archive, crew lodge, season board, cosmetics, settings.
- Subscription buys breadth, convenience, cosmetics, and ongoing content, not moral superiority over free players.

Material mapping decisions

Layer	Material need	Open questions
Summit Present	patch ceramic, alpine fiber, windstone	How handmade vs premium should the starting palette feel?
Breathwright Origin	lungstone, black carbon, pressure clay	Which material actually clears the first Veil band?
Seed Halls	old loam, seedstone, cistern clay	Do gardens become mechanics or stay visual early?
Monument Civic	dressed stone, starstone, memorial clay	How large should first monumental ghost map be?
Furnace/Alloy	copper, tin, slag glass, alloy braces	How much crafting depth before it becomes spreadsheet work?
Road/Water/Law	aqueduct block, civic paver, water gate	When does water routing become real?
Glass/Mechanism	lens, mirror tile, brass fitting	Does Far-Glass restoration use this layer or a separate quest?
Wire/Digital	cable, sensor block, data shard	How rare should recognizable modern tech be?

IP and attraction decisions

Option	Use case	Risk
Original IP only	Best default for v1. Own the mountain, Veil, Bore, and Breathwrights.	Harder initial marketing, but stronger long-term asset.
Public-domain inspiration	Seasonal events or store-page cultural hooks after legal review.	Need copyright, translation, art, and trademark review by territory.
Licensed IP	Only if it brings meaningful user acquisition after retention proof.	Approval friction, cost, and creative distortion.
Journey to the Center of the Earth	Descent event inspiration, geological wonder.	Do not let Verne overshadow Understory.
At the Earths Core	Hollow-earth event inspiration.	Pulp baggage and tonal mismatch.
The Time Machine	Layered future-human resonance.	Could pull game toward time-travel instead of strata.

Practical recommendation

Original IP first. Public-domain-inspired events later. Paid license only after retention proof. Understory is already distinctive enough that a license should not define the first product.

Codex mockup gates

Gate	Mockup deliverable	Pass signal
First 10 minutes	Clickable Summit -> Bore -> seam -> haul -> build flow	Tester understands loop without lore dump.
Touch feel	Placement and trace interaction sandbox	Rounded blocks and seam trace feel premium on glass.
Veil unlock	Old Lung/Breathline before-after scene	Land reveal feels earned, not arbitrary.
Progress objects	Core Sample and Archive shelf	Progress feels physical and collectible.
Economy pressure	D1/D3/D7/D30 paper prototype	Scarcity creates want-list, not frustration.

Decision timing

- Lock now: first 10-minute script, title direction, HEM relationship, Phase 0 material starter set.
- Lock before Phase 0 build: world scale stub, trace gesture behavior, Return Ritual v1, Core Sample v1, draft commit rules.
- Lock before Phase 1: Breathline/Old Lung cause-effect, first Veil clearing, first ghost map size, Archive page format, early timer ladder.
- Lock before soft launch: subscription benefits, prices, named crew boundaries, rewarded ad policy, store timing, telemetry events.
- Lock only after retention proof: public-domain events, licensed IP, second shaft, Far Peak communication, Otherhuman reveal cadence.

Source notes

- This decision register is a companion to Understory Master Scope v6.
- Legal and platform facts still need counsel review before commercial use.
- Public-domain status varies by jurisdiction and can be affected by translations, derivative versions, artwork, and trademark/source-identification issues.
- Idle/tapper numbers are design scaffolds until telemetry exists.